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My All-Time Favorites

Author:
Frank Smith

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My All-Time Favorites

A Dramatic Monologue

Written by Frank Smith

SCENE I

Mrs. Phelan's House.

(Potted plants in every corner. Well-lit thanks to all the windows. Photos of a big, nice guy, ED.)

JANET PHELAN.

(JANET PHELAN (75), born to be an educator, with a bright, soothing wardrobe, smiles as she answers the door.)

JANET: Hello! Yes, hello there. Umm…you'll have to forgive me. When you called on the phone, I thought for sure I'd recognize you. Yet I don't! It's actually an uncommon skill, you know. Being able to recognize students you haven't seen for 20 years. But when you've worked with elementary schoolers as long as I have, you get a good sense for how their faces will look as they grow. I guess that's partly because I get so many visits, years later, from nice students like you. No, no, don't tell me who you are. I'd like to figure it out. Keep it our little guessing game. It shouldn't take me that long. I'm very good at this. Well, all right, then, come on in! Come inside already. It's winter in Montpelier. No need to catch frostbite for the sake of being polite.

(Janet ushers her guest, who will remain unseen, indoors. She gestures for him to have a seat, before serving him a plate of cookies. She then puts a teapot on the stove.)

JANET: I'll just get the tea. Yes, those are the same snickerdoodle cookies I used to make for all of you! Oh, aren't you sweet. Well, it's not exactly the same recipe…I don't make them with quite as much sugar when I'm just making them for myself, and…friends. Do you mind if I call you a friend? The way I see it, once you graduate, I'm no longer your teacher. I'm officially your friend. Uh-huh. That's the law. And so along those lines: please, please, please stop calling me Mrs. Phelan. It's Janet now. So! You said you graduated from 4th grade in 2000? Oh, I remember that class very well. And not just because we were all so worried about Y2K, which ended up being NBD. I just learned that means No Big Deal. Oh, is it that old? Oh my. I tend to be a little behind the times. 10-year-olds aren't necessarily the movers and shakers when it comes to pop culture. Though I do know more about Tik Tok than you might think. There's this one young lady, Morgan Bullock, who Irish step dances. She is talented! She faced some discrimination for being Black, but she overcame the odds. That was true of a number of people in the Class of 2000. Some truly excellent students who struggled with quite a bit of adversity. Honestly, and I'd say this even if you weren't here, several of my all-time favorite students were from that class of yours. Oh, sure, there were the trouble-makers. There always are. I can tell from looking at your eyes that you weren't one of them, though. The trouble-makers, you do try to help. Some, you can. Some, you can't. The high-achievers, they rarely need help. Sometimes they do, though. And when you can't help them…well, I have to be honest with you. I find it crushing.

(Janet takes the teapot off the stove and pours them both a cup of tea.)

JANET: So, class of 2000. Let's see, who were some of the standouts. Oh! I can tell you one right away. James Garner. Same name as the actor. That always tickled me. He was such a little heartbreaker, even back then. The girls in class would come and tell me how they took Cotillion classes with sweet James. You remember. The manners, and the dances. Those girls would race, actually race, to see who would get to dance with him each song. Wonder what happened to him.

(Janet nearly scalds herself while laughing at what her guest says.)

JANET: You're kidding me! Three divorces? I guess he really couldn't make up his mind about those girls. You're not James, are you? Oh, phew. I'd feel much worse about what I just said if you were. No, I know it wasn't that bad. I only might have swapped out a few words here and there, were you he. Let's see, who else did I love. Oh, I know! Little Alison Baker. Just the tiniest little thing! But so much energy. So much! Always making speeches to the rest of the class. And resolving disputes for the other students. A real politician in the making. And you don't need to tell me what became of her. I already know! I just cast my ballot to re-elect her as our mayor. She has done a tremendous job taking care of dangerous intersections all over town. That's an important issue for me, locally. Children can so easily get hurt at those things. Oh my. One did, a few years before you. Clayton O'Malley. Poor dear. Such a sweetheart. Ran into traffic, and…oh. I can't even bear to talk about it. He was such a talented flute player. One of the only students I ever met who could make the recorder sound beautiful. Simply an incredible child. Oh! Another one I adored: Thanh Pham. A trans girl. Now she knew her geography. I don't think I ever saw her get one wrong. Not even when she won the State Competition! A real superstar. You don't know what she's up to, though? Oh, that's too bad. But I'm sure she's well.

(Janet chews on a cookie. She then notices her guest's plate.)

JANET: I'm sorry, did you want a few more? It's perfectly all right. I baked several dozen. It's more than I need for my class on Monday. Take as many as you want. All right, then! I suppose everyone is allowed to watch their figures these days. *(Gesturing to a picture.)* My Ed was never big on that, as you can probably tell. He loved to eat! And to watch others eat. Now I'm quite the baker, but Ed was the real chef in the house. There wasn't a single cuisine he couldn't replicate perfectly. Truly a remarkable man. Miss him every day, but…he's teaching middle schoolers in Heaven, now. I'm sure of it. Oh, that's not to say…well, of course, middle schoolers do pass away, but…rarely. Much more often, they come to visit, like you are. It brings the greatest joy to us educators. We always hope we did a great job with you. But once you leave…we don't know.

(Janet slides away her plate.)

JANET: Oh, look! Now you've got me counting carbs. You are such a terrible influence. Or perhaps a wonderful one. My, my. The Class of 2000. There was, umm, another student I lost track of. Well, of course, there are several. Soccer star Johnny Chao. Heard he got injured in high school, but kept playing anyway. Couldn't get him to take class seriously, but who needs to, when you've got that much skill, I suppose. Eric Lopez. I hope he still sings. What an angelic voice. And, umm…I don't suppose you ever heard from little Nate Abbott once he moved? I expect not. It's all right. That happens every now and then. Students move away. But in his case, well…I have to tell you, I get worried sometimes. I know that might sound silly. Plenty of students never get in touch again. The majority don't, in fact. Even though e-mail has made it easier than ever! But, umm, Nate. Well. It's one of the few times I can remember that I wasn't entirely sure I handled the situation right. Because even 20 years ago – I already had 30 years of experience. So, I was fairly certain my decisions were usually the correct ones. That, and I had been hearing that 50 was the new 30, so I figured I was in the prime of my life! Little Nate Abbott. Brilliant painter. And mathematician. He had it all. And you so rarely see that. So rarely.

(Janet takes the plates, and puts them in the sink.)

JANET: No, no, please, I'll get them later. You are my guest. Sit, please. Sit. I know I'm about to. *(She takes a deep inhale, enjoying the comfort of the seat.)* Can you believe I've had this recliner since you all were in my class? It's true. I seem to remember you were someone who was always on time. Nate, though. He was always running 5 minutes late, at least. One of his few noticeable flaws. Such an adorable little face. Rosy cheeks. Chubby ones. That's why when he came in with one cheek looking rosier than usual – scratched and bloody, actually – I took notice. I immediately took him aside while the other students practiced telling time on the clocks I handed out. I remember, because Susie Lefkowicz kept insisting there was no difference between 3:30 and 9:30 while I was trying, really trying, to get Nate to open up. I pride myself on not losing my temper, but that girl! How could she have known, though. How could any of us have known. What I was trying to do. What I was worried about. I finally convinced Susie to leave us alone by offering her a lime green Jolly Rancher. Her favorite flavor. Mine too, actually. And then I asked Nate: what happened to your cheek, sweetheart? At first, he simply smiled back. Said that was the same color his cheeks always were. It sounded very…rehearsed. I asked him again if anything was the matter. Said he was allowed to say anything he wanted to me, and there would be no punishment. He then told me that he was painting right before school this morning. That explained the marks, AND why he was late. I gently touched his cheek, and…it wasn't paint. That was when I saw it. His lip quiver. His eye twitch. But as soon as it started, it stopped. He said he must have forgotten: his cat scratched him. And then he walked over to explain to Susie why 9:30 was a different time of day. Like the selfless little gentleman he was.

(Janet returns to the sink a moment.)

JANET: Maybe I should wash these now. Before the crumbs stick to the plates. You know how it is. Cinnamon, sugar. They'll be stuck like glue. No, but you're a guest. Those can wait. I'm so sorry. *(She returns to her seat.)* Well, naturally, Nate's explanations didn't exactly set me at ease. Now, only his mother, Lilah, had ever come to parent teacher conferences before. She said that her husband – goodness, I don't think I can even remember his name – was always busy working late at the firm. Family law. Ironic. So I gave Lilah a call, said I'd like to discuss a special gifted program for Nate. Would she mind coming in? Yes, I know that was the tiniest bit deceptive. But when it comes to matters like…these…sometimes bringing people in under optimistic auspices is the way to go. So Lilah came to visit, wearing a beret. Like a real Parisian. I'm not making a joke – she painted in Paris before settling down in Vermont. I guess that's where Nate got his talent from. It was in his DNA. So were other things. I told Lilah that while I did think Nate belonged in a gifted program…there was another reason she was there. The mark I saw on his cheek. And she did that same lip quiver, that same eye twitch that I saw Nate do. She asked me what Nate said. I didn't take that bait. I'm a real Jessica Fletcher when it comes to protecting my children. I said that I was simply interested in what had happened. She said that she was sorry, but she couldn't actually remember anything unusual happening the night before. She closed her eyes, said she was thinking…though to me, it looked more like praying. When she opened her eyes: the tears were gone. Her lips settled. And her words were resolute: she couldn't recall anything odd happening to Nate. But she was so grateful that I was paying close enough attention to him to question whether something might be wrong. With more teachers like me in the public school system, the world would be a better place. But it wasn't a compliment. It was a cop-out.

(Janet fetches the tea pot and pours more tea for her guest.)

JANET: I don't think I'll be having any more tea, myself. I'm feeling a little bit jumpy all of a sudden. Caffeine can do that to you! You enjoy, though. Let's see, where was I. Yes, of course. After the meeting. Well, Nate came to school, late as usual. Much later. About an hour later. And when he did arrive, he was wearing sunglasses. I'm sure I don't have to tell you this, but no one wears sunglasses in Montpelier in November. I asked Nate to take them off. He wouldn't. I then TOLD him to take them off. I do so detest being firm, but I had to see whether he was hiding something. He refused. What I did see, though, were tears streaming from under his sunglasses. That sweet, talented, ten-year-old boy. He begged me, please, just let me do my times tables. I'll be good, I swear I will. I won't make any noise. Just don't make me take off my sunglasses, Mrs. Phelan. *(Takes a moment to inhale.)* I let him keep them on while he got settled, and started his worksheet. Once I could tell he was in a good rhythm – smiling, joking with Susie – I did ask if he wouldn't mind taking them off. I thought I had found my moment, but right away, the tears returned. And in much greater quantity. I asked him to step into the hall with me. He said no. Asked why he was being punished. I assured him he wasn't, he really wasn't. At this point, the entire class had ground to a halt, to watch the two of us interacting. And finally, right as I was about to, I swear to you, get on my knees and plead with him to take off his sunglasses – little Susie Lefkowicz ripped them off his face. Just like that. One swift grab, and they're on the floor. And there was Nate: sobbing tears from those big, beautiful, horribly bruised, ten-year-old eyes.

(Janet gets up, then sits back down again.)

JANET: I'm not sure why I even got up right then, I just…I can't seem to sit still. Well, I'm sure you know, as much as I wished to respect the privacy of Nate, and his mother Lilah – I had to act. Morally, ethically, legally. I was bound to report what I'd seen. So, I set a meeting with the Principal. Which of course involved the police. And both of Nate's parents were required to attend. This was the first – and only – time where I met Mr. Abbott. And I will never forget what I saw. No tearing eyes. No quivering lip. Just a dreadful, horrible stare. The kind of eyes you see in your worst nightmares, where the Devil shows up. He had those. Devil eyes. No matter what anyone said, that was the only face Mr. Abbott wore the entire meeting. But he didn't speak. His wife Lilah behaved completely differently from when I'd seen her last. She said, Mrs. Phelan, this is an outrage. How dare we accuse her and her husband of such a thing. Nate was an artist like her, he had an active imagination, and there was no reason to think that it was anything other than…and I SCREAMED. I screamed like I have never screamed in my life. I screamed, "You are hurting this child. One, or both of you, is hurting this child. He is young. He is beautiful. He is innocent. What is the matter with you!? I hope that only one of you is hurting him, for his sake. And I hope whoever is letting him get hurt thinks long and hard about the kind of person that allows that to happen in their home, to their child." I turned blood-red. I don't know what color Lilah was – she hid her face. And HE wore that Devil's stare. The police asked me to leave. I wouldn't. So, the Principal gently escorted me into the hall. Thanked me profusely, but said they could handle things now. I TRUSTED that what went on behind that door was right.

(Janet rocks herself in her chair, losing her composure.)

JANET: I'm not a mother. You know that. At least not in the traditional sense. But my students.

You, Clayton, Nate. All of them. They are…what they mean to me is…I just can't describe it properly. I try. But I can't. Little Nate Abbott didn't come back to school. Ever again. There are some weeks where I wake up, hoping to see his name show up in my inbox. Praying that it will. I don't think about any other student that way. But what more could I have done for him? Truly. I'm asking. I couldn't have had a softer touch. The abuse would have continued. I couldn't have been firmer. Because then, he may have disappeared sooner. Why can't they all call? Students need to know how much I care. How much I want them all to be okay. Why couldn't Nate call? Could Nate be…like Clayton…I can't bear to think of it. How could I do this? No. How could THEY? It's all so wrong. I'm sorry, Nate. I'm oh so sorry. You'll never know how sorry I am.

(Janet takes her guest's teacup and puts it in the sink. She returns to her seat, breathing heavily.)

JANET: I didn't even ask if you were done. How thoughtless of me. Oh, you were. Oh, good. That makes me happy to hear. I don't suppose – I know there's no reason to think that you would, but – is there any chance you've ever heard from Nate, Richie? Yes, I figured it out a few minutes ago. Richie Loze. The boy who never met a chessboard he couldn't conquer. With long, flowing hair his parents refused to cut, an attitude as liberal as those lovable hippie parents who raised him. I'll tell you how I could tell: you still have those adorable red cheeks… *(Realizing.)* Oh my goodness. No, you're not Richie. You couldn't be. Richie had that mark over his eye, from when he fell in the gravel, that day after playing Off the Wall with the fifth graders. No. Is there a chance…are you… *(The guest finally reveals his identity: Janet sobs joyous tears.)* You are. My goodness, you are. Oh, of course. Little Nate Abbott. But you're not so little anymore. And those cheeks certainly aren't chubby. Oh. You go by Nathaniel now. Is that right. Goodness. And here I was, prattling on…well. That's in the past. Tell me. Please, tell me, my friend. Tell me everything. Really! I see. So, you're telling me that, because of what I said, in that meeting, your mother had the courage to pack up and leave. To escape your father. You had to change your name and address, so he wouldn't find you. And now, your father's passed. Is it terrible if I say good riddance? Oh! I'm so glad you said it first. And now you're okay. You're all okay. Is that right! You and your mother? An exhibition together? Of course, I'd love to see it. Well, yes, I certainly would love to meet your family. What a pure joy that would be. Uh-huh. A little boy of your own. Oh, that's adorable. Little Nate Abbott II. And a girl…really. Come on, you're pulling my leg, now. Really? Janet? Little Janet Abbott? Why? I was only…well. That is very flattering indeed. Thank you, my boy. Thank you. Can I…come on. You don't even need to ask.

(Janet gets up and gives Nate a big, emotional hug.)

JANE: Oh, of course. I've kept you so long. Let me pack you up a few extra cookies. Please, Nate…I mean, Nathaniel. I insist. You can give them to your boy. And your wife. Sonia, was it? As long as she's not watching her figure like I now am. Thanks to you!

(Janet packs up a container of cookies and hands it to him.)

JANET: All right. You be on your way now. Please tell everyone I say hello. Sonia. Nate Jr. Lilah. Janet. Oh, and umm…Nathaniel? I very much do mean it when I say: come back anytime.

THE END.